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The Contractor's Acquisition Starter Kit

A practical field guide for defense contractors, BD professionals, and proposal teams navigating the U.S. Government acquisition landscape — built by the experts at [Acqlerate](#).

Whether you're building your first pipeline or optimizing a mature capture strategy, understanding how the government buys is the foundation of sustainable contract growth. This kit covers the five essential knowledge areas every contractor must master: [contract vehicle types](#), [IDIQ and A&AS structures](#), [who's actually buying](#), [the vocabulary of acquisition](#), and [the costly mistakes that derail even experienced firms](#). Use this as your go-to reference — and share it with your BD, capture, and contracts teams.

Section 1: Task Orders vs. Standalone Contracts

IDIQs, Fair Opportunity, and Contract Structures

Understanding the difference between task orders and standalone contracts is foundational for any defense contractor. A **standalone contract** is a direct award for a specific, defined requirement — it has its own solicitation, proposal, evaluation, and award process. A **task order**, by contrast, is issued under a pre-existing Indefinite Delivery Indefinite Quantity (**IDIQ**) vehicle. The IDIQ itself is the umbrella agreement; task orders are the individual delivery mechanisms under it. Winning a place on an IDIQ vehicle does not guarantee revenue — it guarantees the right to compete for task orders.

An **IDIQ contract** establishes a ceiling value and a minimum guarantee (often nominal) with one or more contractors. The government retains flexibility to order services or supplies over the life of the contract — typically 5 years with options — without re-competing every requirement from scratch. This structure dramatically reduces procurement lead time and gives the government agility in a fast-moving environment.

Single Award IDIQ

One contractor holds the vehicle. All task orders go to that firm without further competition. Highest revenue certainty but harder to win at award. Typically used for highly specialized requirements or when only one qualified source exists.

- Maximum revenue potential per win
- Requires strong technical differentiation
- Less competition post-award
- High incumbent advantage on recompete

Multiple Award IDIQ (MA-IDIQ)

Multiple contractors hold the vehicle. Task orders are competed among awardees under **fair opportunity** provisions (FAR 16.505). The government must give all awardees a fair opportunity to be considered unless a statutory exception applies. This is the dominant IDIQ model in defense contracting.

- Shared pool — must compete for each task order
- Easier vehicle entry, harder revenue certainty
- Requires sustained BD effort post-award
- Fair opportunity exceptions are narrow and scrutinized

Fair Opportunity Exceptions (FAR 16.505(b)(2))

While fair opportunity is the rule, the government may bypass it in specific circumstances: when the need is unusually urgent, when only one awardee is capable, when a sole-source order is in the public interest, when the order must follow an order-specific competition, or when a logical follow-on applies. Contractors should understand these exceptions because they represent both a risk (competitor receives a sole-source order you should have competed for) and an opportunity (your firm may qualify for an exception in the right circumstances).

Feature	Standalone Contract	Single Award IDIQ	Multiple Award IDIQ
Competition Level	Full & Open or Set-Aside	Single competition at award	Competition at vehicle + task order
Revenue Certainty	High (if awarded)	Very High	Moderate — depends on win rate
Entry Difficulty	Moderate to High	Very High	Moderate
Typical Duration	1–5 years	5–10 years	5–10 years
BD Effort Post-Award	Low	Low	High — continuous
Common Use Cases	Unique, defined scope	Specialized capability	Broad services/IT requirements

Section 2: GSA AAS-D and FEDSIM

The Procurement Office Behind Major DoD Acquisitions

GSA Assisted Acquisition Services - Defense (AAS-D) is not a contract vehicle. It is a procurement office within GSA's Federal Acquisition Service (FAS), operated through **FEDSIM**, with roughly **300 employees** supporting defense acquisitions. AAS-D is organized around five defense-focused components: **Army**, **Air Force**, **DoD**, **Geographic Combatant Commands**, and **Navy**.

For contractors, AAS-D matters because it is often the acquisition engine behind large, complex DoD requirements. Understanding how it works helps you identify where opportunities originate, how requirements are shaped, and why some of the biggest defense buys are executed through GSA rather than directly by the customer agency.

What AAS-D Is

A specialized acquisition office inside GSA FAS that supports DoD missions through FEDSIM-managed procurements. It provides the contracting infrastructure, process discipline, and source selection execution for complex buys.

- Not a contract vehicle
- Operates through FEDSIM
- Focused on defense requirements
- Supports major interagency acquisitions

Why It Exists

AAS-D fills acquisition capacity gaps when DoD organizations need speed, expertise, and scale. It is designed for requirements that are too large, complex, or specialized for routine local contracting offices.

- Reduces acquisition workload on DoD teams
- Accelerates award timelines
- Brings deep federal procurement expertise
- Supports highly visible, protest-sensitive buys

Why DoD Agencies Use AAS-D

DoD customers turn to AAS-D when they need acquisition expertise they do not have in-house, when they need to move faster than their internal process allows, or when the requirement is too complex to manage locally. AAS-D is also attractive because it has a **99% win rate on protest challenges**, which makes it a strong choice for defensible, documentation-heavy source selections.

Capability Gap

Used when program offices lack the contracting depth or source-selection bandwidth to manage a major acquisition internally.

Speed

FEDSIM's centralized model can reduce friction and move complex requirements forward faster than a traditional decentralized process.

Complexity

Best suited for large, multi-stakeholder efforts that require rigorous documentation, evaluation structure, and protest resilience.

Protest Strength

AAS-D's highly disciplined approach contributes to an exceptionally strong protest record.

What AAS-D Buys for DoD

The portfolio is dominated by a handful of service categories. Contractors should recognize where their capabilities fit and how contract type expectations may shape pricing and proposal strategy.

Program Management & Acquisition Support

Planning, oversight, governance, and acquisition execution support for major defense programs.

IT & Telecommunications

Networks, platforms, communications infrastructure, and enterprise IT services.

Special Studies & Analysis

Independent assessments, analytical support, market research, and decision support work.

Computer System Design & Development

Software, systems engineering, integration, and development of mission systems.

Professional Engineering Services

Technical engineering support across acquisition, design, test, and sustainment activities.

Contract type mix: AAS-D awards are commonly structured as **FFP (~40%)** and **CPAF (~24%)**, so contractors should be prepared for both fixed-price execution and cost-plus performance risk allocation.

Key DoD Customers

These are some of the most important DoD organizations using AAS-D. **ASTRO** is a flagship **MA-IDIQ** vehicle frequently associated with platform support services and major federal mission support work.

Customer	Program / Vehicle	Notable Value
Dept. of the Air Force	DC3	\$347M
U.S. Army USACE	RITS	\$1.3B
Defense Threat Reduction Agency	JIDO	\$326M
SOCOM	Special operations requirements	Major recurring customer
Navy	Mission support and technical services	Major recurring customer

What Contractors Need to Know

Search the Right Place

Watch **SAM.gov**, not agency-specific portals. Search for **Federal Systems Integration and Management Center** to find relevant opportunities.

Expect Rigor

Source selections are documentation-heavy and highly structured. Proposals must be clear, traceable, and defensible.

Don't Assume Incumbency Helps

Incumbents do not automatically retain an advantage. AAS-D competitions are designed to test current value and execution risk.

Understand the Interagency Dynamic

GSA contracting officers execute the procurement, while the DoD program office owns the requirement and technical evaluation inputs.

Position for ASTRO and Platform Support

ASTRO alignment can be valuable if you offer platform support, technical integration, or mission-enabling services.

**Pro Tip:** Build a weekly routine around SAM.gov searches for **Federal Systems Integration and Management Center**, then monitor FEDSIM/AAS-D opportunities consistently. The best teams review the pipeline every week so they can shape capture early, not after the solicitation drops.

Section 3: Who's Buying

Navigating the Air Force Contracting Enterprise — AFICC/ESS, Base-Level, and MAJCOM Contracting

One of the most underestimated competitive advantages a defense contractor can develop is a precise understanding of **who actually issues the contract**. The Air Force contracting enterprise is not monolithic — it is divided into distinct organizational layers, each with different authorities, contract size thresholds, mission focus, and levels of accessibility to industry. Confusing these layers leads to misaligned BD strategy, wasted proposal resources, and missed opportunities.

AFICC / Enterprise Sourcing Squadrons (ESS)	Base-Level Contracting Squadrons	MAJCOM / Service Component Command
Air Force Installation and Mission Support Center's contracting arm. ESS units handle large-dollar, enterprise-level acquisitions across installations and functional areas. Think sustainment, services, IT infrastructure.	Installation-specific contracting offices handling day-to-day requirements under simplified acquisition thresholds and mid-tier contracts. High transaction volume, lower average contract value. Strong relationship opportunity for small businesses.	Commands like USAFE-AFAFRICA , ACC , AMC , and AFSOC have contracting support aligned to their mission. Acquisitions here are often operationally sensitive, higher classification, and tied to theater or combat support requirements.

The **Air Force Installation Contracting Center (AFICC)** and its Enterprise Sourcing Squadrons represent the most accessible entry point for mid-size to large contractors seeking multi-year service contracts. ESS offices typically manage requirements from **\$1M to well over \$100M**, running formal source selections with written proposals, oral presentations, and structured evaluation criteria. These competitions reward thorough market research, strong PWS/SOW alignment, and credible past performance.

Base-level contracting squadrons are where relationships matter most. These offices process thousands of smaller actions annually — blanket purchase agreements, simplified acquisitions, and sole-source justifications under SAP thresholds. For small businesses and new market entrants, base-level contracting provides the fastest pathway to building past performance. Contracting Officers at the base level value reliable incumbents highly, making early market entry and COR relationship-building critical.

MAJCOM-aligned contracting, such as the contracting operations supporting **USAFE-AFAFRICA** or **Air Combat Command**, handles operationally-driven requirements that often carry unique classification, OCONUS, or mission-specific constraints. These opportunities are less visible on **SAM.gov** and often require security clearances, theater knowledge, and existing relationships with program offices. Entry is harder but competition is typically less crowded.

Dimension	AFICC / ESS	Base-Level Contracting	MAJCOM / Component
Typical Contract Size	\$1M–\$100M+	Under \$1M (SAP range)	\$500K–\$50M+ (varies)
Competition Type	Formal source selection	Simplified, BPA, sole-source	Formal to streamlined
Entry Difficulty	Moderate–High	Low–Moderate	High (clearance, access)
Visibility (SAM.gov)	High	Moderate	Low–Moderate
Relationship Weight	Moderate	Very High	High
Best For	Mid/large contractors	Small business, new entrants	Cleared, mission-specialized firms

Section 4: Key Acronym Glossary for Contractors

70+ Essential Acquisition Terms — Organized by Category

The U.S. defense acquisition ecosystem runs on acronyms. Fluency in this vocabulary is not optional — it is a professional baseline. From proposal writing to contract performance, the ability to interpret and use these terms accurately signals credibility to government customers and sets professional standards within your own team. This glossary is organized by category for rapid reference. Use it to onboard new staff, prep for source selection, or refresh before a government meeting.

Contract Types

- **FFP** — Firm Fixed Price
- **T&M** — Time and Materials
- **CPFF** — Cost Plus Fixed Fee
- **CPIF** — Cost Plus Incentive Fee
- **CPAF** — Cost Plus Award Fee
- **IDIQ** — Indefinite Delivery Indefinite Quantity
- **IDC** — Indefinite Delivery Contract
- **BPA** — Blanket Purchase Agreement
- **OTA** — Other Transaction Agreement
- **MAC** — Multiple Award Contract
- **TO** — Task Order
- **DO** — Delivery Order
- **BOA** — Basic Ordering Agreement

Acquisition Process

- **FAR** — Federal Acquisition Regulation
- **DFARS** — Defense FAR Supplement
- **RFP** — Request for Proposal
- **RFQ** — Request for Quotation
- **RFI** — Request for Information
- **SOO** — Statement of Objectives
- **SOW** — Statement of Work
- **PWS** — Performance Work Statement
- **QASP** — Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan
- **SSP** — Source Selection Plan
- **SSEB** — Source Selection Evaluation Board
- **SSA** — Source Selection Authority
- **LPTA** — Lowest Price Technically Acceptable
- **BVTO** — Best Value Tradeoff
- **SAP** — Simplified Acquisition Procedures
- **SAT** — Simplified Acquisition Threshold

Roles & Personnel

- **CO** — Contracting Officer
- **KO** — Kontract Officer (alternate abbreviation)
- **COR** — Contracting Officer's Representative
- **ACOR** — Alternate COR
- **PCO** — Procuring Contracting Officer
- **ACO** — Administrative Contracting Officer
- **TCO** — Terminating Contracting Officer
- **PM** — Program/Project Manager
- **PO** — Program Office
- **BD** — Business Development
- **CP** — Capture (or Capture Manager)
- **PPM** — Proposal/Program Manager
- **TPOC** — Technical Point of Contact

Performance & Compliance

- **CPARS** — Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System
- **PIRS** — Past Performance Information Retrieval System
- **DCAA** — Defense Contract Audit Agency
- **DCMA** — Defense Contract Management Agency
- **CDRL** — Contract Data Requirements List
- **DID** — Data Item Description
- **EAC** — Estimate at Completion
- **ETC** — Estimate to Complete
- **BAC** — Budget at Completion
- **SPI** — Schedule Performance Index
- **CPI** — Cost Performance Index
- **EVMS** — Earned Value Management System
- **POP** — Period of Performance

Organizations & Programs

- **DoD** — Department of Defense
- **DAF** — Department of the Air Force
- **USAF** — United States Air Force
- **USSF** — United States Space Force
- **AFICC** — AF Installation & Mission Support Center Contracting
- **ESS** — Enterprise Sourcing Squadron
- **AFMC** — Air Force Materiel Command
- **USAFE** — US Air Forces in Europe
- **ACC** — Air Combat Command
- **AMC** — Air Mobility Command
- **MAJCOM** — Major Command
- **PEO** — Program Executive Office
- **SAF** — Secretary of the Air Force
- **GSA** — General Services Administration
- **SBA** — Small Business Administration

Small Business & Socioeconomic

- **SB** — Small Business
- **SBP** — Small Business Program
- **SDVOSB** — Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Business
- **VOSB** — Veteran-Owned Small Business
- **WOSB** — Women-Owned Small Business
- **HUBZone** — Historically Underutilized Business Zone
- **8(a)** — SBA 8(a) Business Development Program
- **SDB** — Small Disadvantaged Business
- **NAICS** — North American Industry Classification System
- **PSC** — Product Service Code
- **CAGE** — Commercial and Government Entity Code
- **UEI** — Unique Entity Identifier (SAM.gov)
- **OSDBU** — Office of Small and Disadvantaged Business Utilization



Pro Tip: Government evaluators and contracting officers will form immediate impressions of your team's professionalism based on how accurately you use acquisition terminology in proposals, white papers, and meetings. Misusing terms like SOW vs. PWS or CO vs. COR signals inexperience and can undermine an otherwise strong technical proposal.

Section 5: 5 Most Common Mistakes Contractors Make

Avoid These Pitfalls Before They Cost You the Contract

Even experienced defense contractors leave significant revenue on the table by repeating the same acquisition errors year after year. These are not obscure edge cases — they are systematic gaps in pipeline strategy, relationship management, and compliance posture that show up across firms of all sizes. Recognizing these patterns is the first step to eliminating them from your capture and delivery operations.

1	No Pipeline Strategy — Chasing vs. Planning The most common and costly mistake: treating BD as reactive rather than strategic. Contractors who chase every opportunity on SAM.gov without a disciplined pipeline framework waste proposal resources, burn out their teams, and win at low rates. A mature pipeline strategy identifies target customers 12–18 months before RFP release, maps vehicle opportunities aligned to your NAICS codes and capabilities, and scores opportunities by pWin (probability of win) before committing proposal resources. Without this, you are funding your competitor's market research.
2	Ignoring the COR — Focusing Only on the CO The Contracting Officer's Representative is the government's day-to-day technical interface during contract performance — and one of the most influential voices in CPARS ratings and recompete positioning. Contractors who treat the COR as an administrative checkpoint rather than a strategic relationship miss the single best source of performance feedback, requirement shaping intelligence, and past performance narrative. Build a structured engagement plan with the COR from contract kickoff. Deliver proactive status updates, document issues in writing, and ensure your PM treats every COR interaction as a performance evaluation in progress.
3	Confusing PWS and SOW — Proposing the Wrong Way A Statement of Work (SOW) tells you <i>what to do</i> in prescriptive, task-level detail. A Performance Work Statement (PWS) tells you <i>what outcome to achieve</i>, leaving the method to the contractor. These are not interchangeable — and responding to a PWS with an SOW-style proposal (listing activities instead of outcomes) is a red flag to evaluators. Worse, it suggests your team doesn't understand performance-based contracting, which is the dominant acquisition model in services. Always read the solicitation's work description type carefully and tailor your technical approach accordingly. PWS-based proposals should describe your management framework, metrics, and outcomes — not a labor hour breakdown by task.
4	DCAA Compliance Gaps — Discovered at the Worst Time The Defense Contract Audit Agency conducts pre-award surveys, incurred cost audits, and forward pricing reviews that can kill a contract award or trigger costly remediation during performance. Contractors — especially those transitioning from commercial work to cost-reimbursable contracts — frequently discover DCAA compliance gaps only after award, when the pressure is highest. Common gaps include inadequate timekeeping systems, unallowable cost pooling, missing written policies for compensation and travel, and indirect rate structures that don't align to contract requirements. Establish a compliant accounting system before pursuing cost-type work, not after. Engage a DCAA-savvy CPA or contracts attorney early.
5	No Recompete Plan — Losing What You Already Won Contractors routinely focus 90% of their capture energy on new business while neglecting the most winnable opportunity in their portfolio: the contract they already hold. Recompete planning should begin at contract award — not 12 months before expiration. A recompetete plan documents performance wins, maintains CPARS narrative alignment, tracks staffing continuity risks, monitors competitive intelligence on challenger firms, and coordinates capture strategy with delivery teams in real time. The incumbent win rate on federal contracts is not as high as most contractors assume — and a poorly executed recompetete can erase years of revenue in a single award decision.

Continue Your Acquisition Education with Acqlerate

Defense Acquisitions Academy — Built for Contractors Like You

This Starter Kit is your foundation — but winning in the defense contracting space requires continuous learning, updated market intelligence, and mastery of the full acquisition lifecycle. **Acqlerate** has built the industry's most contractor-focused acquisition training curriculum, designed specifically for BD professionals, capture managers, proposal leads, and contract administrators supporting the U.S. Government.



Module 1: Acquisition Fundamentals

Master the FAR/DFARS framework, contract types, and acquisition lifecycle from pre-solicitation to award. The essential foundation for every BD and contracts professional.



Module 3: Proposals That Win

From PWS-responsive technical volumes to compliant pricing structures — learn how evaluators score proposals and how to write to the evaluation criteria every time.



Module 5: Pricing & DCAA Compliance

Understand cost-type contracting, build compliant accounting systems, navigate DCAA audits, and price to win without leaving money on the table.



Module 2: Pipeline & Capture Strategy

Build a disciplined, pWin-driven pipeline. Learn how to identify, qualify, and sequence opportunities across IDIQ vehicles, standalone contracts, and GWACs.



Module 4: Contract Performance & CPARS

Deliver winning performance, manage COR relationships strategically, and build the CPARS record that powers your next recompetes or new business proposal.



Module 6: Small Business Growth Strategies

Leverage set-aside programs, 8(a), HUBZone, SDVOSB certifications, and teaming strategies to accelerate growth and position for graduation to full-and-open competition.

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Why Acqlerate?

- Built by acquisition practitioners — not academics
- Contractor-focused curriculum (not just government PMs)
- Aligned to current FAR/DFARS and DODI policy
- Air Force, Space Force, and DoD-relevant content
- Self-paced modules with practical tools and templates
- Credentialing recognized by acquisition professionals

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